

Australia Daily Brief

Friday, October 9, 2026

1,970 words · 8 min read

RE: Fiji demands US evidence on China-linked bribery · NZDF joined Five Eyes 'Arcadia' after cutoff warning · Pacific Resilience Facility hits US\$190m · Chalmers delays ATO card ban · Firmus pulls \$5bn float

ASX 200

8,717

+0.40%

AUD/USD

0.6982

+0.43%

NZX 50

13,749

+0.50%

NZD/USD

0.5614

-0.05%

IN THIS ISSUE [Top Stories](#) · [Overnight](#) · [Stat](#) · [AUKUS](#) · [Pacific](#) · [New Zealand](#) · [Canberra](#) · [Markets](#) · [Upcoming](#) · [The Wire](#)

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji asked Washington to produce evidence behind its sanctioning of a Chinese-born Fijian businessman accused of bribing officials on Beijing's behalf, as the US embassy in Suva warned of China-linked 'systemic geocriminality' across the region.
- 2 New Zealand's Defence Force signed onto the Five Eyes digital backbone known as Project Arcadia a month after an internal briefing warned that staying out would leave it 'effectively cut off' from allied information exchanges.
- 3 Pledges to the Pacific Resilience Facility reached US\$190 million as Pre-COP31 closed in Nadi and leaders adopted the Taku Pakasoa Declaration.

• TOP STORIES

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

Fiji demands US evidence behind China-linked bribery sanctions

The US State Department sanctioned **Zhao Fugang**, director of the Overseas Chinese Service Center in Fiji, alleging he "abused his public position by paying bribes to Fijian citizens to advance China-based government, business and criminal interests." Zhao, a Chinese-born naturalised Fijian citizen who runs property and tourism businesses in Suva and owns the Yue Lai Hotel, is banned from the United States along with his immediate family. Fiji pledged cooperation against transnational crime but asked Washington to substantiate the allegations; the US embassy in Suva separately warned on Facebook of China-linked operators infiltrating local governments, a pattern security experts call "systemic geocriminality."

per Pacific Island Times: "US flags China's 'systemic geocriminality' in Pacific island region" · also AFP: "Fiji demands US provide evidence Chinese official paid bribes for Beijing"

NZ-DEFENSE

NZDF joined Five Eyes digital backbone after internal cutoff warning

Newly released briefings show a New Zealand Defence Force commander warned in April that without committing to Project Arcadia the NZDF "will not have access to these foundational capabilities, becoming effectively cut off from future FVEY information exchanges." The United States announced the build of the digital backbone linking the five militaries in May; New Zealand signed up the same month. The papers said participation would let the NZDF go "far beyond" what it could afford alone, "without loss of national control," and that Defence would seek additional funding in Budget 2027.

per RNZ Pacific (wire): "Warning NZ could be cut off from Five Eyes info for not signing up to digital super-system"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Pacific Resilience Facility pledges reach US\$190 million before COP31

Pacific Islands Forum Secretary General **Baron Divavesi Waqa** welcomed *US\$13.3 million* in new commitments to the Pacific Resilience Facility, taking total pledges to US\$190 million and following Fiji's earlier US\$10 million contribution. The pledges landed as Pre-COP31 wrapped up in Nadi, with Australia announcing a separate \$3 million for a region-led climate facility. Forum members are pressing major emitters for faster emissions cuts and easier access to climate finance ahead of COP31 in Türkiye next month.

per PNG Post-Courier: "Forum SG Waqa welcomes US\$13.3m in new Pacific climate finance pledges ahead of COP31" · also Islands Business: "Pacific climate fund draws pledges as leaders press major emitters for support"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

[AFP commissioner warns of hostile governments using local actors in Australia](#) · The Daily Telegraph
Australian Federal Police Commissioner **Krissy Barrett** set out what she called a "diabolical reality" facing Australia, in which hostile foreign governments recruit actors already inside the country to pursue their aims. The warning came in interviews marking her first year in the job.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Australian and New Zealand police hit Lone Wolf network in joint action](#) · ABC News
Taskforce Morpheus, which brings together every Australian state and territory police force with Commonwealth agencies, ran a national day of action across Australia and New Zealand, making 20 arrests and laying 69 charges. Officers executed 18 search warrants and 10 firearms compliance checks and seized cocaine, MDMA, illicit tobacco and vapes. Queensland Detective Superintendent **Troy Pukallus** said the Lone Wolf Outlaw Motorcycle Gang is assessed as a "very high threat" in organised crime, driven by drug importation, money laundering and violence.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

[Mass fish deaths in PNG's Middle Fly prompt calls for investigation](#) · ABC Pacific
Footage shared with the ABC appears to show thousands of dead fish along riverbanks in the Middle Fly district of Papua New Guinea's Western Province, with officials saying they have not yet been able to reach the site. Marine biologist **Rachel Sapery James**, who has investigated similar kills in New Ireland Province, said the biggest driver is "the El Niño and drought," though other stresses may be contributing. Similar incidents have been reported elsewhere in PNG.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[Canberra to release final plan to keep more LNG output at home](#) · Bloomberg

Australia will publish its final plan to retain a larger share of liquefied natural gas production for the domestic market, a decision watched closely by long-term contract holders in North Asia. Brent crude traded at *102.94*, up 2.61 percent.

• STAT OF THE DAY

US\$190 million

Total pledges to the Pacific Resilience Facility

New commitments of US\$13.3 million lifted the region-led climate and disaster fund as Pre-COP31 closed in Nadi.

PNG Post-Courier

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · ABC POLITICS

[Varghese and Pezzullo argue Australia's dependence on Washington](#)

A United States Studies Centre debate in Sydney pitted former Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade secretary **Peter Varghese** against former Home Affairs secretary **Mike Pezzullo** on whether Australia over-relies on the United States and needs a plan B, with Geraldine Doogue hosting. ABC's Global Roaming revisited the assumptions underpinning ANZUS and AUKUS and which other partners Australia might cultivate.

• PACIFIC WIRE

TONGA · RNZ NATIONAL

[Tonga by-elections return relatives of MPs unseated for electoral offences](#)

Tonga's two newest MPs were elected on Thursday, with voters in both by-elections choosing family members of former Cabinet ministers who had been removed from parliament over electoral offences.

TUVALU · ABC PACIFIC

[Taku Pakasoa Declaration framed as a unity test for COP31](#)

Tuvalu's Climate Minister **Maina Talia** said having world leaders see his country's vulnerability first hand mattered in building a united Pacific front ahead of COP31 in Türkiye. He said the name Taku Pakasoa reflects the relationship between sea and land and the need "to work collaboratively with the Pacific and with the world leaders to ensure that we deliver on what we have promised in the past." Tuvalu co-hosted the high-level Pre-COP31 meeting with Fiji and Australia.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

[Pacific ministers weigh roadmap to end fossil-fuel dependence](#)

Pacific island ministers have begun discussing a regional roadmap to move away from fossil fuels, seeking to convert the region's long dependence on imported fuel into a case for renewables investment and energy security.

SAMOA · ABC PACIFIC

Samoa opposition says PM shamed the nation with Nazi salute video

Samoa's opposition said the Prime Minister has brought "shame and disgrace" on the country after a video emerged showing him giving a Nazi salute while saying "heil Hitler." The same programme reported questions over Solomon Islands senior officials using public funds for medical treatment overseas.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG electoral commissioner says 2027 procurement irregularities addressed

Electoral Commissioner **Nicole Haley** confirmed that procurement irregularities identified in preparations for Papua New Guinea's 2027 national general election have been addressed, in evidence to a special parliamentary committee hearing on elections.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG Electoral Commission turns to Starlink for voter awareness

The Electoral Commission is scaling up voter awareness campaigns with Starlink connectivity as it works to modernise enrolment and lift citizen participation before the 2027 poll, Haley said.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Three Fiji police officers charged with murdering a fellow constable

Fiji's Office of the Director of Public Prosecutions sanctioned joint murder charges under Section 237 of the Crimes Act against three officers over the February death of Lami Police Constable **Peniasi Racagi**, 24, whose body was found floating off a beach near Suva. Police Commissioner **Rusiate Tudravu** directed the charges be laid and the three appeared at the Suva Magistrates Court.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

Teachers' union chief's threat inflames Fiji constitutional reform debate

Fijian Teachers Association general-secretary **Paula Manumanunitoga** wrote on Facebook that critics questioning the place of iTaukei chiefs in governance should "shut the [expletive] up and mind your own business before we catch you and roast you in earth ovens." The post, which invoked the 1874 cession of Fiji to Queen Victoria, landed in the middle of the constitutional reform debate and days before Fiji's 56th independence anniversary.

FIJI · FBC NEWS (FIJI)

Reserve Bank of Fiji hits data gaps turning green policy into investment

RBF Chief Manager Financial Systems Development **Caroline Waqabaca** said limited data is making it difficult to measure the impact of Fiji's Green Finance Taxonomy. The policy framework exists, she said, but the investment it is meant to mobilise has not yet followed.

● NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

New Zealand censor says it cannot block livestreamed US execution

The Classification Office said it "cannot classify a livestream event as it is taking place, and we, nor any other body, has the authority to block access to a livestream event," after the Pentagon said the December 3 execution by firing squad of former Army psychiatrist **Nidal Hasan** would be broadcast. Rights groups are pressing governments to protest the decision with Washington. The office said New Zealand's threshold for banning content is high and must be balanced against freedom of expression.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ PACIFIC (WIRE)

NZ First renews fireworks ban push after National and Labour rebuff

New Zealand First said legislation banning the public sale and private use of fireworks is already drafted and ready to introduce within the first 100 days of the next government, after the National and Labour leaders

dismissed the idea in a debate. Leader **Winston Peters** rejected the framing of fireworks as "a freedom issue," calling it "a right to peaceful and harmonious living." The party lodged a member's bill proposing a ban in November last year.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Chalmers delays ATO credit card ban and picks up the surcharge bill

Jim Chalmers delayed the Australian Taxation Office's ban on credit card payments and agreed that the Commonwealth will temporarily fund surcharge costs, after pressure from business groups. The ATO will keep accepting cards to the end of June 2027, with the Treasurer saying the money buys time to consult. Australia's largest business organisation welcomed the delay.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Gosling to seek Labor preselection despite pending assault case

Luke Gosling, the member for Solomon, will recontest his Northern Territory seat at the next federal election despite being prosecuted over an alleged assault on the NT administrator. Gosling said future Territorians would "shake their head" at the prosecution.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Greens think tank pitches publicly owned supermarkets as One Nation rises

The Greens' think tank has proposed an Australian version of New York mayor Zohran Mamdani's publicly owned supermarket plan, as the party looks for its own left-populist surge. **Waleed Aly**, a Monash University politics lecturer, questioned whether the formula wins votes while support for One Nation continues to grow.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Superannuation at 12 percent reopens the retirement savings argument

With the compulsory contribution rate set at *12 percent*, Australians will on average draw more cash income a year in retirement than they earned while working. At the past two federal elections the Coalition proposed letting home buyers withdraw part of their superannuation for a deposit.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Price fuels speculation about a move to a Queensland seat

Northern Territory senator **Jacinta Price** has stoked speculation about switching to a Queensland seat after a heavily booked tour of the state, The Australian reported.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

AFP chief stops short of backing chatbot extension to under-16 ban

Adelaide University data produced with the AFP-led Australian Centre to Counter Child Exploitation found more than one in three Australian children sexually victimised online tell no one or turn to an AI chatbot. Commissioner **Krissy Barrett** declined to directly endorse extending the government's under-16 social media ban to chatbots, saying "anything that helps to keep our kids safer is obviously something we support."

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Firmus scraps \$5 billion ASX float, citing market conditions

Nvidia-backed data-centre operator Firmus withdrew its ASX listing application, abandoning what was set to be one of Australia's biggest share market debuts, saying the offer would not appropriately reflect its long-term

growth prospects. CDC Data Centres told a federal inquiry it had ended its own dealings with Firmus, citing the need for "a certain degree of rigour" and warning against "rogue operators."

TRADE-ECONOMY · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Productivity Commission chair on why growth has stalled

Productivity Commission chair **Danielle Wood** told the Guardian's political editor Tom Imlroy that AI integration, housing affordability and climate adaptation are the binding policy challenges. The Reserve Bank lifted interest rates to a 15-year high last week, with governor **Michele Bullock** describing productivity as "doing nothing."

TRADE-ECONOMY · REUTERS

Glencore expects electrification demand to drive Australian listing

Glencore said the global electrification trend should drive strong uptake for its planned Australian listing, a test of local appetite for exposure to copper and other transition metals.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Card surcharge ban prompts cash discounts, but not a cash revival

Some merchants are offering discounts for cash since the Reserve Bank banned card surcharges, though analysts expect little change in the dominance of electronic payments. The ASX 200 closed at 8,717, up 0.40 percent, with the Australian dollar at 0.6982.

• UPCOMING

OCT
10

Fiji marks its 56th independence anniversary

Falls amid an unresolved constitutional reform debate over the role of iTaukei chiefs.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Starts the formal count-down on a campaign in which NZ First is running hard on its own policy announcements.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it the Budget 2027 funding request for Project Arcadia.

NOV
2026

COP31 in Turkiye

Pacific leaders will press the Taku Pakasoa Declaration's demands for faster emissions cuts and climate finance access.

JUN
30

ATO ban on credit card payments takes effect after delay

The Commonwealth carries surcharge costs until then, a direct budget cost from this week's back-down.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Don't mistake the Pacific islands forum leaders' meeting for Pacific regionalism

Sione Tekiteki, a senior lecturer at Auckland University of Technology and a former Pacific Islands Forum Secretariat director, argues the real test of regionalism is not attendance at Leaders' Week in Palau but whether the region's room to disagree is shrinking.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

Twenty-five years on: what Australia gave Afghanistan, and what it still owes

The piece dates Australia's Afghanistan commitment from **John Howard's** invocation of the ANZUS Treaty on 14 September 2001 and the establishment of Operation Slipper on 11 October, with the first Australian special forces arriving by early December.

AU-POLITICS

ABC POLITICS

Do the 'frontier wars' belong in the Australian War Memorial?

ABC Religion and Ethics revisits the long-running argument over whether the Australian War Memorial should commemorate the frontier wars, a question that keeps returning to the Memorial's council and its federal funding.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ABC POLITICS

The Diplomats: Jenny Bloomfield on three decades in Australian diplomacy

Jenny Bloomfield, who arrived in Australia from Greece aged 12 and later served as ambassador to Greece, reflects on almost three decades as a diplomat and public servant.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

[Read online](#)

[Past issues](#)

You are receiving the Australia Daily Brief as a member of the CSIS Australia Chair distribution list.

This newsletter is automatically generated, so it may contain errors. Please check all information and sources before citing. To report errors or other issues, please contact Andy Lim at alim@csis.org.

generated 6:23 AM ET

[↑ BACK TO TOP](#)